MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 1 — Unit 4: Prose - Historical Development

MILTON TO THE PRE-ROMANTICS • M21EG03DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Prose expands through political argument, spiritual narrative, diaries, periodical essays, satire, criticism, and new forms of extended fiction.

Start with a picture

A writing desk holds a pamphlet, a private diary, a weekly essay, a letter, and a novel. Each addresses a different situation, but techniques can move between them.

1. Argument and spiritual narrative

Milton’s prose intervenes in religious and political controversies, including the licensing debate in Areopagitica. Its argument is historically situated; do not assume a seventeenth-century defence of unlicensed printing means identical rights for every group in the modern sense.

Bunyan’s The Pilgrim’s Progress uses allegory to make a spiritual journey visible. Names and events can have symbolic meanings while also creating memorable narrative action.

2. Diaries

Samuel Pepys and John Evelyn record personal and public experience through particular social positions. A diary’s immediate detail can be valuable, but its writer selects and interprets events. Private writing is not automatically an objective historical record.

3. Periodical essays

Addison, Steele, and later Johnson address readers through repeated publication. Character sketches, observation, irony, and moral reflection turn everyday conduct into discussion. A returning persona or fictional club can create continuity across separate essays.

The medium helps establish a reading habit and a public voice, although access to that public remains unequal.

4. Satire and criticism

Swift uses narrative and comparison to question intellectual pride and institutional claims. Dryden, Pope, and Johnson develop influential critical arguments in different forms. Johnson’s Dictionary and Lives of the Poets contribute to language and literary judgement, while his essays examine conduct and self-deception.

Burke’s political prose adds rhetoric about institutions, history, change, and public feeling. Do not classify every argumentative writer as holding one Enlightenment position.

5. The novel’s development

Defoe draws on travel, providential narrative, and detailed accounts. Richardson develops letters and inward experience. Fielding uses an overt narrator and comic organisation; Smollett and Sterne expand satire, movement, and formal experiment.

Women writers, including Behn, Haywood, and Burney, are important to this history. A story of three male inventors would erase much of the field.

6. What to compare

Ask about purpose, readership, speaker, structure, and style. A compressed aphorism, a descriptive scene, and a sustained argument guide readers differently. Prose is a flexible range of methods, not simply language without rhyme.

Quick check

1. Is allegory only an abstract lecture? **No; it represents ideas through narrative.**
2. Is a diary perfectly neutral? **No.**
3. Did one writer invent every aspect of the novel? **No.**

Build an exam answer

1. Group prose by purpose and situation.
2. Explain argument, diary, and allegory.
3. Discuss the recurring reader of periodicals.
4. Connect older practices with novelistic methods.
5. Include stylistic and gender diversity.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not describe prose history as a single style or exclude earlier and women’s fiction from the rise of the novel.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

How did different prose practices contribute to the growth of literary and public expression?

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

The expansion of prose should be understood through multiple practices rather than one uniform improvement in style. Political controversy required persuasion; spiritual narrative gave experience an exemplary shape; diaries recorded a situated life; periodicals constructed repeated exchanges with readers. These purposes helped develop techniques that could also move into fiction.

The periodical essay is especially important because it makes continuity possible without a single long plot. A recurring voice or club connects separate observations, creating a sense of a shared social world. Its accessible address can widen discussion while preserving assumptions about whose manners deserve authority.

The novel draws on this wider field of letters, travel accounts, journalism, and life writing. Defoe’s detail, Richardson’s epistolary form, and Fielding’s narrative commentary illustrate different combinations rather than stages of one inevitable formula. Women’s writing and earlier prose fiction are essential to the account.

A strong answer therefore connects genre and institution with specific textual methods. It avoids treating prose as merely a container for ideas: who speaks, how an example is arranged, and what kind of reader is imagined all shape the argument’s force.

Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt’s assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. Do you agree that the diaries of Pepys and Evelyn gave prose writing a new life? Explain.
2. Write an essay on the rise of periodicals in the 18th century.
3. Discuss the emergence and proliferation of novels in the 18th century.
4. The critical writings of the 18th century include the contributions made by Dr Samual Johnson and his circle. Elaborate.
5. Write a short note on the influence of women writers in 18th-century novel writing.